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expanded"

like NREGA and Bharat Nirman.

When I talk of inclusive growth, I do not mean merely the programmes and projects but also their implementation. Both taken together will lead us to inclusive growth and there cannot be a specific or fixed parameter for it. For instance, if compare the last four years between 2006-07 and 2009-10 and if we make a comparison between the aggregate figure of the Plan allocation and gross budgetary support to the Plan allocation, we will find that in all these 10 projects, the budget has been stepped up from Rs 48,000 crore to Rs 1,23,000 crore. In the next five years, this may quadruple.

I can give you an example from my personal experience. When I was a village boy, I had to go to school and there was no road. I aspired to see a day when there will be a road. So when the local body constructed a road, I had immense satisfaction. Today none of my villagers

will be satisfied with mud roads and 40 years ago, when I became a MP, the first demand they made was that of a metalled road. Now they are not satisfied with a single-laned metalled road; they want it to be connected to the nearest highway so that it should have minimum two lanes and if possible more than that. Access to information has raised the aspirations of people and policymakers must respond to that.

There is no doubt in this Budget, I have taken a risk. When the economy was going down and we accepted Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management, in most states we were able to maintain a prudent level of the fiscal deficit and the revenue deficit. At that point of time, to burst the ceiling suddenly and to leave a fiscal deficit of 6.8 per cent GDP was a tremendous risk but I had to do it because of the international financial crisis and its adverse impact that was being faced by all, including us.

I cannot expect to have overnight recovery in the industrialised world and all forecasts have said so; even the latest forecast of IMF has predicted that the global growth rate would be 2.5 per cent. But the substantial contribution will be coming from China, India and other major emerging economies. In such a scenario, the only alternative left was to step up the developmental outlay by one stroke to the extent of 37 per cent, from Rs 2,43,000 crore to Rs 3,25,000 crore with the objective of generating demand in the rural sector and the urban sector.

Inclusive growth is imperative and it will have to be enlarged and expanded. This year, we faced drought but felt confident because of the huge buffer stock of foodgrain. Thanks to the farmers of India, the wheat surplus is 17.7 million tonnes as of now. Even if I exclude 4 million tonnes of buffer stock and 3 million tonnes of strategic reserve, I will be left with a surplus of 10.7 million tonnes as of April 1, 2010. Of course thanks to late monsoon, the problem is not as alarming as it was visualised in the month of July and early August.

I would reiterate that inclusive growth is imperative and it is on. We shall have to work within our federal structure. Be it taxation, devolution of financial resources, or planning at the micro level which is to be implemented by the states and at the macro level which is to be formulated by National Development Council (NDC) with the cooperation of the state chief ministers as each and every one of them is the member of NDC, inclusive growth is imperative. We shall have to implement it collectively. ■

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